

Blogs Mean Business

Corporate blogging can be innovatively used to boost business and improve communication

Mithun Kidambi

Blog, one of the fastest growing applications on the Internet, is increasingly making its presence felt in the corporate world. Generally viewed as an online journal that records anything and everything that people think—be it about their new car or someone else's, blogs have moved on to become one of the most potent marketing, PR and CRM tools a company can have.

It is easy to customise a blog and companies worldwide are quickly picking up the trend. Besides using the blog to promote themselves, corporate offices use it to maintain a certain level of transparency within their ranks. Companies can also exploit blogs to engender strong relationships with their customers and the media.

Here, we attempt to answer some basic questions: What are the uses of a blog? Why is it smart business to have a corporate blog? Who in the company must be allowed to blog? What are the rules that must be followed while maintaining a corporate blog? What sort of companies would gain the most if they set up a blog?

Let's Get Started!

A blog is very similar to a Web page that can be updated using a simple WYSIWYG (what you see/what you get) interface. Most major Internet companies and portals host a blog service such as Google's Blogspot and MSN's MSN Spaces, that have tens of millions of registered users.

Various methods can be applied if you want to set up a corporate blog. Blogging tools can be found on the Internet, and a few can be downloaded for free. The article in this section last month (*Digit*, December 2005) spoke about setting up a wiki at work.

All wikis come loaded with a blogging application, so you don't need to set up a separate blog if you've already have a wiki installed. Most content management systems today come with a blogging application that can be installed. So don't bother downloading a blogging application if your company's Web site has a one installed.

A few firms also opt to let their employees and management post their blogs on independent service providers such as Xanga and Blogspot. However, if the corporate blog you plan to set up aims

